Career Advancement Research Readout

March 2025

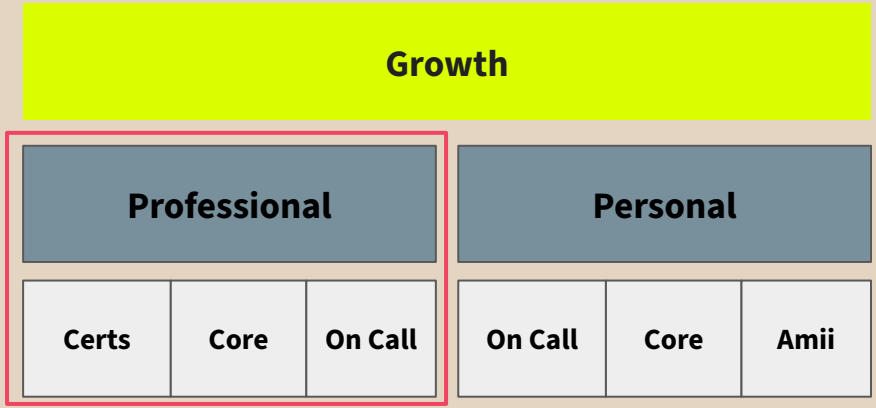
MasterClass

Background

1. A key pillar of our 2025 strategy is to **build a cohesive and complimentary portfolio.**

2. We know that the most important driver when considering a learning platform is that users believe that it will help them **achieve their personal and professional goals.** Source.

3. We wanted to better understand the professional side:
   a. In order to… understand the **journey** of career advancers and identify key **personas**
   b. So that we can…**identify and understand our priority professional development consumer target across the portfolio** and empower them achieve their professional goals.



Methodology

Phase: Qualitative	Qual Readout	Phase: Quantitative	Qual + Quant Readout	Rollout
8 Focus Groups conducted amongst motivated career advancers	Sharing of qual findings: Link here.	Survey amongst n1000 motivated career advancers to validate what we learned in qual	Certificates Readout: Where we are today	This week: PM team Creative team Monthly Content Update

The Career Advancement Journey

Three stages of career advancement

%s shown next to Early / Mid / Late = % of each stage amongst motivated career advancers

	Early (29%)	Mid (53%)	Late (10%)
Who they are	**More entry-level roles** (defined as coordinator, analyst or associate levels).	**Middle part** of their career, often managing others. (defined as manager through sr. director levels)	**More senior roles** (defined as VPs and above)
Motivators *% Selected in top 3 motivators in career advancement*	**Growing their <u>experience</u>** Most driven of all stages to want to **increase their earning potential**. But, as many are still establishing themselves in their chosen industry, they are **eager to learn** and seek positions that make them feel they are making **a positive impact and proud** of their work. <u>Intrinsic Motivators:</u> Continuously learn and evolve (21%), Make a positive impact through my work (14%), Do something I'm proud of (14%) <u>Extrinsic Motivators</u>: Increasing earning potential (45%), Promotion (18%)	**Growing their <u>influence</u>** While **salary and promotion** are still at the top of their goals, specifically, they're aiming to **take on leadership roles** which come with greater responsibility and **influence**. <u>Intrinsic Motivators</u>: Make a positive impact through my work (16%), Continuously learn and evolve (15%) <u>Extrinsic Motivators</u>: Increasing earning potential (37%), Promotion (20%), Advance into a leadership role (13%)	**Growing <u>themselves</u>** Least-driven of all stages by extrinsic factors. Instead, more intrinsic factors like **achieving personal fulfillment** and continuing to **sharpen their existing skills and knowledge** are among the most important drivers. <u>Intrinsic Motivators</u>:Continuously learn and evolve (23%), Make a positive impact through my work (21%), Achieve personal fulfillment (17%), Enhance my existing skills or expertise (16%) <u>Extrinsic Motivators</u>: Increasing earning potential (30%)
Goals	**<u>Seeking upward mobility through learning and challenge:</u>** Working towards **upward mobility** much more than other stages. To achieve that momentum, they strive to **learn** and **say "yes" to new challenges** and opportunities. Working to maintain **stability** in their trajectory.	**<u>Driving career trajectory towards influential leadership roles:</u>** Still prioritize extrinsic factors, but these goals are nuanced to also include developing soft skills like **leadership and management skills**. When it comes to promotions, they seek opportunities to advance into even **higher leadership roles** with the aim of leveraging these roles to make a **meaningful impact**.	**<u>Pursuing legacy and self-actualization through ongoing development:</u>** Focus on earning potential decreases as stage evolves, but is still a top priority for. But they are much more likely to prioritize growth by becoming an **expert in their field, taking on new challenges**, and continuing to **grow their skillset**. Making a meaningful impact is also core to their identity.
Barriers	· **Limited opportunities** for promotion (32%) · **Economic conditions** or job market challenges (20%) · Organizational **restructuring** (e.g., layoffs or downsizing) (16%) · Manager / employers **not recognizing** the value of my knowledge or experience (15%) · Workplace **conflicts or toxicity** (14%)	· **Limited opportunities** for promotion (25%) · **Economic conditions** or job market challenges (21%) · Facing **competition** within my industry (17%) · Difficulty **balancing** work and personal life (16%) · Manager / employers **not recognizing** the value of my knowledge or experience (14%)	· **Economic conditions** or job market challenges (27%) · Facing **competition** within my industry (24%) · Organizational **restructuring** (e.g., layoffs or downsizing) (17%) · **Limited opportunities** for promotion (16%)
Development	Pursuing the **fewest development activities on average** (2.6)	Pursuing **more development activities on average** (3.2)	Pursuing the **most development activities on average** (3.4)
Opportunities *Scored above average (20+)*	· Certificate programs (41) · Expert-led classes (38) [core for prof dev] · Personalized learning paths (28) · Skill assessment & benchmarking (25) · Professional network (20)	· Professional network (28) · Certificate programs (27) · Expert-led classes (24) [core for prof dev] · Personalized learning paths (22)	· Expert-led classes (29) [core for prof dev] · Professional network (28) · Skill assessment & benchmarking (22) · *Certificate programs (14)*

Career Advancement Personas

Four Career Advancement Personas

%s shown next to Persona Name = % of each persona amongst motivated career advancers

	The Strategist (29%)	**The Voyager** (17%)	**The Loyalist** (28%)	**The Balancer** (26%)
Stage	**Early**: 32% / **Mid**: 56% / **Late**: 12%	**Early**: 27% / **Mid**: 67% / **Late**: 6%	**Early**: 31% / **Mid**: 58% / **Late**: 10%	**Early**: 34% / **Mid**: 53% / **Late**: 13%
Focus & Motivators *How they think about career advancement*	**Setting clear goals and strategically navigating their career** to achieve long-term success. *More likely to be aiming to: Continuously learn and evolve (52%), Earn a promotion (39%)*	**Discovering their passions** and finding fulfilling work that aligns with their interests. *More likely to be aiming to: Align my career goals with my personal values (30%)* *Less likely to be aiming to: Increase my earning potential (45%), Advance into a leadership role (15%)*	**Excelling in their current job or company** and gaining recognition for their accomplishments. *More likely to be aiming to: Earn a promotion (47%), Advance into a leadership role (33%)* *Less likely to be aiming to: Continuously learn and evolve (38%), Achieve personal fulfillment (31%)*	**Balancing career goals with personal responsibilities**, a desire for stability, flexibility, and continued growth. *More likely to be aiming to: Make a positive impact through my work (46%)*
Approach *How they navigate their career journey*	**Seeks skill development** and continuous improvement to **proactively advance their career.**	**Seeks new experiences**, welcomes different roles and industries, and prioritizes self-discovery.	**Seeks opportunities to demonstrate their expertise** and take on challenges to add value to their role, company, or industry.	**Seeks roles that offer security** and **personal growth** without sacrificing their values. Often prioritizes their impact on others (e.g., legacy, family, etc.) over upward mobility.
Development Activities	**The most involved with active career development, specifically formalized training:** · 3.6 development activities (avg) · Taking online courses or certificate programs (46%) · Actively seeking feedback from colleagues or leaders (39%) · Participating in company-sponsored or company-provided development programs (32%)	**Not as involved with development activities, formal or informal:** · 3.1 development activities (avg) · Networking with professionals within my field (28%) · Attending conferences, workshops, or industry events (24%) · Participating in company-sponsored or company-provided development programs (17%)	**Though they are not as engaged as others, they still participate within their company/industry:** · 3.1 development activities (avg) · Networking with professionals within my field (41%) · Attending conferences, workshops, or industry events (35%) · Taking online courses or certificate programs (32%)	**They are pretty involved in their development, but most activities are informal or interpersonal learning:** · 3.5 development activities (avg) · Reading books, articles, or industry reports (41%) · Networking with professionals in my field (39%) · Attending conferences, workshops, or industry events (37%) · Providing mentorship to others (25%)
Opportunities to Reach Them	· Certificate programs (39) · Expert-led classes (30) · Professional network (26)	· Certificate programs (23) · Expert-led classes (21)	· Professional network (29) · Expert-led classes (27) · Skill assessment & benchmarking (25) · Certificate program (23) · Personalized learning paths (20)	· Expert-led classes (40) · Certificate programs (31) · Professional network (30) · Personalized learning paths (25) · Goal setting & learning dashboard (23) · Skill assessment & benchmarking (21)

Strategist vs. Loyalist Deep Dive

	Strategist	Loyalist
Seeking	**Breadth**: looking for broadening their knowledge base with the aim of increasing earning potential	**Depth:** focused on deepening their knowledge to move upward in their chosen field.
Key Motivation	Increase their earning potential, wherever that might take them	Move upward from where they currently are
Their view on: Role Growth	Heavily focused on upward mobility with clear aspirations for specific future roles.	Not as aggressive with seeking high leadership positions but still aiming to achieve growth.
Their view on: Career Moves	More open to taking on risks and job changes for better opportunities.	Tend to want to stay with their employer long-term and look for internal promotions rather than external.
Their view on: Financial Growth	Very focused on earnings and wealth.	Prioritize suitable income, but not massive jumps.
Their view on: Certifications & Education	Pursues certs and degrees as a way to fast-track career advancement.	View education as a way to improve skills in their current role.

Our Primary Target for our Career Advancement Solutions

Disclaimers

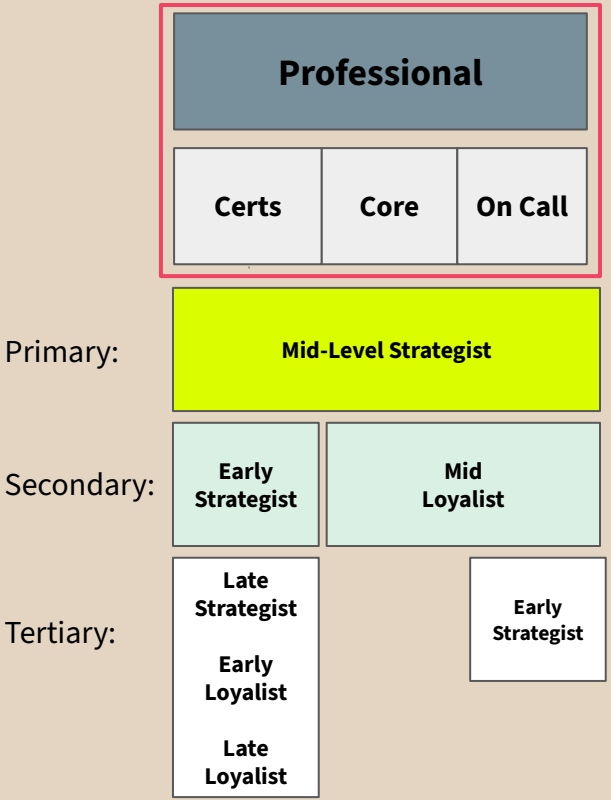
Our recommended primary target is for design / marketing / development purposes for Certificates at a program level / On Call / Core for Professional Development

It is not at the exclusion of other potential users.

We will continue to focus each Certificate subject with more specifics as to who that Certificate should be for; similarly, we will continue to do so for Core as well.

Priority Targets Across the Portfolio

	Early	Mid	Late
Strategist	#2 Priority - Certs #3 Priority - On Call	**#1 Priority -** **Certs** **On Call** **Core for prof dev**	#3 Priority - Certs
Voyager	x	x	x
Loyalist	#3 Priority - Certs	#2 Priority - On Call & Core for prof dev	#3 Priority - Certs
Balancer	x	x	x



How we got here

Part 1

- Generally, **Balancers** and **Voyagers** are not as proactive in taking on their own formal professional development so they were eliminated as priority targets

- This leaves us with **six potential targets** for career development across our portfolio

	Early	**Mid**	**Late**
Strategist	**Potential**	**Potential**	**Potential**
Voyager	X Not particularly involved with development since they're still navigating their own journey.	X *Still not especially involved in proactive career development.*	X *Continue to be the least hands-on with their career development.*
Loyalist	**Potential**	**Potential**	**Potential**
Balancer	X *More focused on finding work that makes them feel they're making a positive contribution.*	X *In full swing of juggling work-life balance; career advancement and skillset growth are not necessarily a priority.*	X *Focused on legacy and impact from the experience they have already gained, and career advancement is low on the list of priorities.*

How we got here: Certificates

Part 2

- For each product, we then looked at both the size of the target opportunity and the value they place on that product as a professional development solution
- When we combine the two metrics, we get a stack rank that leads us to our primary Certificate target being the **Mid-Level Strategist**

Stage	Person	Stage x Persona	Size of Target	Certificates MaxDiff Score	Certificates MaxDiff Rank	Size x Certificate Score	
Mid	Strategist	Mid-Strategist	16%	38	1	6.1	**#1 Priority**
Early	Strategist	Early-Strategist	9%	51	1	4.6	**#2 Priority**
Early	Loyalist	Early-Loyalist	9%	46	1	4.2	**#3 Priority**
Mid	Loyalist	Mid-Loyalist	17%	14	5	2.4	**#3 Priority**
Late	Strategist	Late-Strategist OR Late-Loyalist*	7%	18	3	1.2	**#3 Priority**

How we got here: On Call

Part 2

- When we look at coaching, the highest performing score is from **Mid-Level Strategists** as well

Stage	Person	Stage x Persona	Size of Target	Human Coaching MaxDiff Score	Size x Coaching Score
mid	Strategist	Mid Strategist	16%	33	5.2
mid	Loyalist	Mid Loyalist	17%	13	2.2
early	Loyalist	Early Loyalist	9%	9	0.9
early	Strategist	Early Strategist	9%	-2	-0.2
late	Strategist	Late Strategist OR Late Loyalist	7%	-8	-0.6

How we got here: Core for Professional Development

Part 2

- And when we look at Core for professional development, defined as expert led video classes focused on professional development, the highest performing score is from **Mid-Level Strategists** as well

Stage	Person	Stage x Persona	Size of Target	Core MaxDiff Score	Size x Core Score
Mid	Strategist	Mid Strategist	16%	28	4.5
Mid	Loyalist	Mid Loyalist	17%	25	4.3
Early	Strategist	Early Strategist	9%	35	3.2
Late	Strategist	Late Strategist OR Late Loyalist	7%	26	1.8
Early	Loyalist	Early Loyalist	9%	28	1.8

What we are solving for them

What they are up against

HELP THEM GAIN THE KNOWLEDGE AND SKILLS TO STAND OUT, IN ORDER TO INCREASE THEIR EARNING POTENTIAL

We are living in an incredibly competitive job market due to macro global instability and uncertainty.

Mid-Level Strategists are driven to maintain a sense of security by staying competitive compared to others. They aim to do this by growing their knowledge and skill set to increase their earning potential.

Mid Level Strategist

Summary

The Mid Strategist is defined by their approach: **setting clear goals and strategically navigating their career to achieve long-term success**. They are **dedicated, committed, driven, open-minded,** and **proactive.** Majority are **optimistic** about achieving their goals.

They are **primarily motivated by extrinsic factors**: increasing their earning potential, earning a promotion, and advancing into influential leadership roles.

They are **conscientious about development** and actively seek it out. They are mapping out pathways to leadership and **proactively invest in upskilling, networking, and strategic opportunities for visibility**. They may pursue MBA or leadership programs, but are also seeking more affordable or accessible options.

Hear from: Josh

What they are up against

1. Uncertainty about the current economic climate and desire for upward mobility pushes them to want to stay **competitive** to maintain a feeling of security. [Barriers: economic conditions / market challenges (27%), competition within industry (20%)]

2. Aiming for **promotion**, oftentimes externally, by growing their knowledge/education and willing to take the steps required to achieve it. [Barriers: limited opportunities for promotion (23%), lack of clarity on next steps (15%)]

Goals

1. Increase earning potential (48%)
2. Advance into an executive or sr. leadership position (34%)
3. Develop my leadership or management skills (29%)
4. Take on new challenges that align with my career goals (28%)
5. Earn a promotion (27%)

Dev. Triggers

1. Desire to advance (57%)
2. Personally motivated to learn and grow (45%)
3. Needing to learn new skills to stay competitive (35%)
4. Receiving constructive feedback (24%)
5. Influenced by professional network (24%)

Key Demos & Stats

- **Size:** 16%
- **Mean Age:** 43 | **Gender**: 51% M
- **Titles**: 64% Manager / 13% Senior Manager / 20% Director / 3% Sr. Director
- **Management**: 52% have been managing people for 5+ years with 70% managing teams of 5+
- **Learning Orientation:** 72% Achievers
- **Industries**: finance, retail, ecomm, tech, healthcare, real estate
- **Functions**: Operations, Finance, HR, IT, Support, Strategy, Data, Dev.

Certificate Subjects

Types: Emerging technologies for professional development (51%), General professional development / MBA (48%), Skill-based professional development (43%)

Top Tier 1 Subjects:

- AI (42%)
- Strategic Leadership (42%)
- Project Mgmt (39%)
- Data Analysis (38%)
- Strategic Planning (36%)
- Growth Strategy (35%)
- Team Leadership (35%)

How we win

Benefits:

- Real world hands on experience
- Company partners
- Institution partners
- Affordability vs. formal education
- High quality content
- Credibility

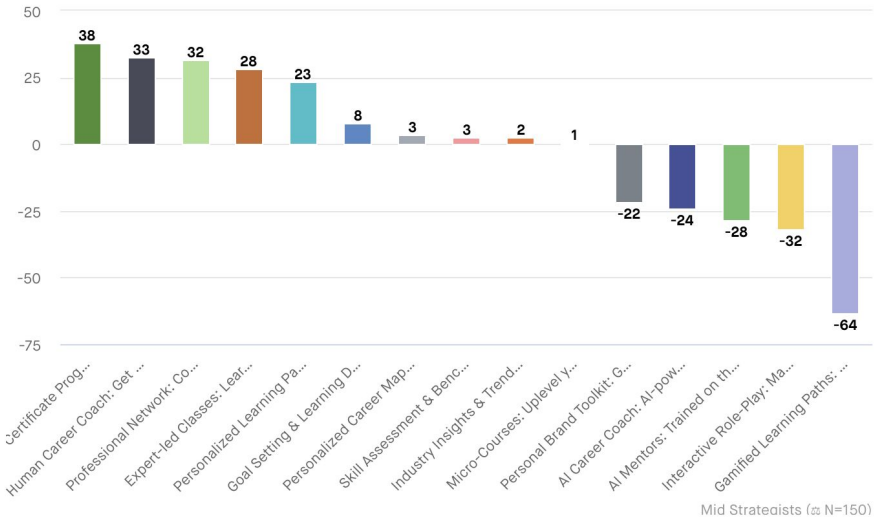
Resources

Certificates / Education: Formal university education, LinkedIn Learning, Coursera, Google Career Certificates, Microsoft Learn.
Podcasts: The Art of Speaking Up, How to be Awesome at Your Job, The School of Greatness, Others
AI: ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini
Relationships: Networking, mentorships

Solution Stack Ranking for Mid-Level Strategist

*Based on **value** to their professional development*

Certificate Program	38
Human Career Coach	33
Professional Networking	32
Expert-led Classes	28
Personalized Learning Paths	23
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard	8
Personalized Career Mapping	3
Skill Assessment & Benchmarking	3
Industry Insights & Trends	2
Micro-Courses	1
Personal Brand Toolkit	-22
AI Career Coach	-24
AI Mentors	-28
Interactive Role Play	-32
Gamified Learning Paths	-64



MaxDiff Score is the percentage of how often an item is chosen as best minus the percentage of how often an item is chosen as worst. Positive score: an item is chosen more often as best than as worst. Negative score: an item is chosen more often as worst than as best. The higher the score the more important/preferred the item.

Opportunities Roadmap

How we thought about next steps

Crawl

Timing: < 1 year

Phase Objective: Build immediate awareness, value, and credibility for MasterClass within career advancement

Walk

Timing: 1 - 3 years

Phase Objective: Deepen personalization, utilization, and retention

Run

Timing: 3+ years

Phase Objective: Create a robust, adaptive ecosystem for lifelong career development

	Mid Strat	Early Strat	<1 Year	1-2 years	2+ years
Certificate Program	38	51	Launch core offering with industry partners	More Certs in More Categories	Ecosystem of Resources
Human Career Coach	33	-2	Research: What does a lightweight offering here mean? Do we proceed with human coach connections or modify AI coaching that addresses key hesitations?	Integrate with AI coaching to address hesitations	Human Coaching Matchmaking
Professional Networking	32	19	Research: Surprising, what is our role in this space?	Initial Networking Feature	Develop robust professional connection platform
Expert-led Classes	28	35	Test: Upsell/Bundle to Core Content. Later, Individual At Work		Exclusive Classes / Offerings
Personalized Learning Paths	23	14	User can select projects most relevant to their role/industry; Personalized feedback on projects / quizzes Research: What are the other personalized learning experiences we'd want to deliver?		AI-driven adaptive learning paths that evolve with career progression
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard	8	15	Basic progress tracking functionality User articulates goal at beginning of course.	Research: How might we help users work towards longer term career goals, with certificates as key moments along that journey?	Comprehensive career progression tracking with predictive career planning
Personalized Career Mapping	3	4	Research: What industries + roles would be most important to serve? How do we do this credibly in a way that is feasible and scalable?	Interactive career pathing with industry benchmarks	Real-time labor market integration with personalized opportunity matching
Skill Assessment & Benchmarking	3	22		Develop comprehensive benchmarking tools	
Industry Insights & Trends	2	-15		Create industry-specific content and trend analysis	
Micro-Courses	1	10	Module 0 for AI certificates		To consider as our content ages.
Personal Brand Toolkit	-22	-17	1-click Add to LinkedIn		
AI Career Coach	-24	-22	See [Human Career Coach] Line		Develop and test advanced AI guidance systems
AI Mentors	-28	-34			
Interactive Role Play	-32	-20			Build simulation system for practical skills
Gamified Learning Paths	-64	-43	Progress Bar		Enhance engagement through comprehensive game mechanics

Next Steps - Career Coach | Qual context by features here

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
On Call				
			Coaching Dev	
Certs				
			In Certs, recommend coaching resources OR help users create their own coach GPT	Test Coach Bundled with Certs

a.

Next Steps - Networking (Certs Lens) Qual context by features here

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
On Call				
Certs		Competitive Research Brainstorm, Prototype, Prioritize	Post Completion, Where do users go?	

Next Steps - Personalization (Certs Lens) Qual context by features here

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
On Call				
Certs				
			Behavioral Analysis	
		Competitive Research		
		Brainstorm, Prototype, Prioritize		
			Launch something	

Follow Up: Gen Z vs. Total

Macro View of Gen Z in the Workplace

Purpose over Paycheck

Deeply values-driven. They seek meaningful work and want to align with employers whose missions and values reflect their own—especially on issues like sustainability, social justice, and equity.

74% say they want a job that makes a positive impact on the world.

Flexibility is Non-Negotiable

Remote or hybrid work is a must for many.

They prioritize work-life balance and mental health more openly.

Rigid hours or micromanagement are major turnoffs.

Entrepreneurial Spirit

Many see corporate jobs as stepping stones, not long-term destinations.

They're open to freelance work or gig economy roles.

They value creative freedom and autonomy over traditional career ladders.

Faster Job Switching

They don't expect to stay in one job or career for long.

They're more open to job-hopping to gain skills, find a better fit, or preserve their wellbeing.

Mental health and psychological safety are non-negotiables, and they're quicker to quit if the culture is poor or values don't align.

Shorter Attention Spans, Faster Feedback Loops

Used to quick gratification via social media, they expect real-time feedback at work.

They value constant development and learning opportunities, but in bite-sized, accessible formats.

Key Differences: Gen Z vs. Total

Personas	More likely to identify as **Voyagers** and less likely to identify as **Loyalists**. But are still most likely to be **Strategists**.
Goals	46% more likely than average to have their primary goal be **'discover the right industry or role for me'.**
Motivators	**Values-Driven:** 21% more likely to have their top motivator be **do something I'm proud of** (#1 motivator) | 25% more likely to want to align their career with their personal values **Reputation:** 50% more likely to want to build credibility in their field or industry | 28% more likely to want to take on more responsibility **Exploration**: 46% more likely to want to explore different career paths
Career Feelings	**Exploring Phase**: 4x more likely to be exploring different career paths **Side Hustles / Non-Traditional Path:** 23% more likely to be freelance, consultant, or gig worker **Dissatisfied but Motivated**: 85% more likely to be dissatisfied with their career journey so far | 23% more likely to feel motivated about their future **Uncertain or Stuck:** 49% more likely to be unsure about next steps | 43% more likely feel stuck in their current situation
Barriers	**Lack of clarity, guidance, or confidence:** 70% more likely lack of clarity on next steps | 31% more likely lack of guidance | 45% lack of confidence to achieve next step **Toxicity:** 41% more likely to indicate workplace conflicts or toxicity
Development Activities	**Seek active feedback:** 37% more likely to be actively seeking feedback from colleagues or leadership **Side projects help them develop:** 50% more likely to be working on side projects **Rely on social and other media more:** 34% more likely to be watching YouTube tutorials, podcasts, or other social media for development **Use AI more:** 23% more likely to be using AI tools for career development
Descriptors	**Softer approach:** Top three descriptors of themselves are **thoughtful, flexible, caring** vs. top three for total pop is dedicated, driven, committed

Solution Stack Ranking for Gen Z

*Based on **value** to their professional development*

Expert-led Classes	34
Professional Network	29
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard	24
Personalized Learning Paths	22
Certificate Program	21
Human Career Coach	14
Personalized Career Mapping	14
Personal Brand Toolkit	5
Skill Assessment & Benchmarking	1
Industry Insights & Trends	-6
Interactive Role-Play	-15
Micro-Courses	-20
Gamified Learning Paths	-39
AI Career Coach	-42
AI Mentors	-48

Overall product opportunities for this group align with Mid-Level Strategist, including:

- Core
- Networking
- Personalization (Goal setting, learning paths, career mapping)
- Certificates
- Coaching

However, the order of importance does shift, with video content and networking coming to the top, rather than certificates and coaching.

Also, personalization matters more to this group specifically.

5 Product and Positioning Thought Starters for Gen Z

1. **Key problem to solve: help them discover themselves, their career paths (whatever it may look like), and give them the guidance, clarity, and confidence to achieve their next step. Discovery, exploration, and helping them with what's next is key.**
    a. Supporting them on their journey of figuring out what work aligns with their passions and values, what career paths exist, how to find what they're proud of, and how to get them unstuck or unsure about what's next would be a huge unlock for them.

2. **Personalization** really matters to them and is expected - how can we give them the goal setting, personalized learning paths, and personalized career maps that they desire and have it feel really tailored to their individual needs and situations?
    a. Ensuring that the career maps are not just traditional ones is essential as well - their long term destinations can vary greatly compared to previous generations.

3. **Core professional development content in short clips** would resonate with this younger generation, who has shorter attention spans and is more used to instant gratification and bite-sized, short formats like on social
    a. They are already turning to YouTube, podcasts, and other social media more for professional development than average, so how can we tap into this user behavior using our video content while also ensuring we're additive + differentiated?

4. **Certificates**:
    a. Capstone is a perfect side project that they could be doing to further their development. Positioning it to Gen Z as a side project for them to work on and be able to share with others may be appealing.
    b. Exclusive access to a private network at the end of their certificate experience may be very appealing to this group who values **networking** and **authentic, curated, and community-based exclusivity** ("exclusivity" should feel like an inside-track, not a gated palace and not elitist)

5. **On Call:**
    a. They actively seek feedback, so positioning the On Call coaching experience to them as a **faster and always available feedback loop** may appeal to them.
    b. Support coaching for their **entrepreneurial spirit** - Mark Cuban to start, and other more Gen Z entrepreneurial coaches would resonate
    c. Tailor scenarios that resonate most with Gen-Z: **workplace toxicity**, **job switching, mental health at work, flexibility**, etc.
    d. **They are already more likely to use AI** to support their career development, so how can we position On Call to them in a way that is differentiated?

Appendix

Updated 3/12/25

Our Vision for MasterClass Certificates

Creating a comprehensive, personalized, and career-focused ecosystem that empowers professionals to thrive amid shifting market demands.

Phase 1

Establish market foothold
Launch + Validate (2025)

Focus: 4-6 certificates in high ROI topics with world's best companies

Phase 2

Diversify portfolio
Strategic Expansion (2026-27)

Focus: Scale to 15+ certificates with career pathways and flexible purchasing models.

Phase 3

Career advancement platform
Ecosystem Growth (2028+)

Focus: Build career ecosystem with comprehensive catalog, integrated career resources, and personalized learning paths.

MasterClass CERTIFICATES

Updated 3/12/25

2025 Certificate Product Investment Allocation

To drive $7M revenue at 2x ROAS and validate future investment

Drive Revenue Growth

Launches, Ads, Pre-Paywall Experiments, Promotions, Virality

50%

Enhance Learning Experience

Table stakes LMS features

20%

Differentiate the Product

Unique / Advanced Features + Value

20%

Improve Our Infrastructure

Streamline Ingestion, Upgrade Admin, Upgrade AI Tooling

10%

MasterClass CERTIFICATES

Updated 3/21/25

2025 Certificates Roadmap

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
Drive Revenue Growth (50%)				
Certificate Launches	Support Content Creation		Anthropic + 2 Certificates	1-3 Certificates
Growth Experiments		Design + Build	Growth Experiments	
Enhance the Learning Experience (20%)				
Cert Post-Paywall	Build + QA of Launch Feature Set		New Active Learning Features	
Differentiate the Product (20%)				
Cert Post-Paywall	Build + QA of Launch Feature Set		Bundle with Core?	Bundle with On Call?
Improve our Infrastructure (10%)				
Infra		AI Tooling + Ingestion	Streamline Ingestion	Admin Improvements

Features / Solutions Shown

With descriptions

1. **Human Career Coach:** Get personalized career guidance in live 1:1 sessions with a certified human coach.
2. **AI Career Coach:** AI-powered coach trained by top certified coaches to provide structured, goal-focused career guidance. With human-like emotional intelligence, it provides personalized strategies to build skills, overcome challenges, and achieve your professional goals, anytime, anywhere.
3. **AI Mentors:** Trained on the wisdom and lived experiences of the world's top leaders, AI mentors provide deep insights, strategic advice, and ongoing mentorship for your long-term success.
4. **Interactive Role-Play:** Master high-stakes career moments, like salary negotiations, tough conversations, and interviews, through AI-powered simulations with real-time feedback and personalized strategies.
5. **Personalized Learning Paths:** Get a learning experience built just for you, with customized courses, assessments, and projects tailored to your background and ambitions.
6. **Personalized Career Mapping:** Explore exciting career paths with an interactive tool that suggests tailored roadmaps based on your skills, interests, and industry trends.
7. **Skill Assessment & Benchmarking:** Know where you stand, identify your strengths, uncover skill gaps, and get a clear plan to reach the next level in your career.
8. **Micro-Courses:** Uplevel your skillset with quick, high-impact courses that help you stay ahead and earn badges in trending skills.
9. **Gamified Learning Paths:** Turn learning into a game, earn streaks, badges, and climb leaderboards while mastering new skills in a fun and engaging way.
10. **Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard:** Set clear career goals and monitor progress with a personalized dashboard that visually tracks your skill development and career milestones.
11. **Industry Insights & Trends:** Stay ahead of the curve with the latest trends, in-demand skills, salary benchmarks, and career growth strategies tailored to your industry.
12. **Personal Brand Toolkit:** Get tools and guidance to showcase your expertise and elevate your professional brand with a standout resume/portfolio and polished LinkedIn profile.
13. **Professional Network:** Connect with alumni, peers, and potential collaborators to expand your career opportunities and industry connections.
14. **Certificate Program:** Earn industry-recognized certificates co-developed with top companies and universities, proving your expertise and accelerating your career growth.
15. **Expert-led Classes:** Learn from the world's best through high-quality video lessons, gaining insider knowledge, practical skills, and inspiration to grow in your professional life.

Josh - Stack Rank of Features

With descriptions

Top 3:

AI Career Coach (hear from him here)
Personalized Career Mapping (here)
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard

Bottom 3:

Industry Insights & Trends
Personal Brand Toolkit (here)
Alumni Network

Full Detailed Reports

1. Research Plan
2. Qual Readout

Stagexpersona	mid-Strategist	early-Strategist	early-Loyalist	mid-Loyalist	late-Strategist OR late-Loyalist
Size	16%	9%	9%	17%	7%
Certificate Program	38	51	46	14	18
Human Career Coach	33	-2	9	13	-8
Professional Networking	32	19	14	37	20
Expert-led Classes	28	35	28	25	26
Personalized Learning Paths	23	14	18	26	2
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard	8	15	3	8	-8
Personalized Career Mapping	3	4	9	1	-4
Skill Assessment & Benchmarking	3	22	32	21	18
Industry Insights & Trends	2	-15	-13	9	5
Micro-Courses	1	10	-8	-1	4
Personal Brand Toolkit	-22	-17	-12	-27	9
AI Career Coach	-24	-22	-37	-30	9
AI Mentors	-28	-34	-50	-46	-23
Interactive Role Play	-32	-20	-13	-11	-24
Gamified Learning Paths	-64	-43	-35	-45	-28

On Call / Core Prof Dev: Secondary Target

Disclaimers

Our recommended primary target is for design / marketing / development purposes for On Call / Core for Professional Development

It is not at the exclusion of other potential On Call users

What we are solving for them

What they are up against

PRIMARY: HELP THEM PERFORM AT THEIR PEAK AND PROVE THEIR VALUE TO MOVE UP

At this point in their career, a sense of limited opportunities for promotion, feeling like their managers or employer do not recognize their value, and a fear of organizational restructuring makes it difficult for Mid-Level Loyalists to reach their advancement goals.

By giving them the support they need to stand out internally so that they can be recognized and rewarded, we can help them position themselves for promotion into more influential and senior / late stage roles.

Mid Level Loyalist

Summary

The Mid Loyalist is defined by their approach: **Excelling in their current job or company and gaining recognition for their accomplishments**. They are **dedicated, detailed, thoughtful,** and **proactive.** Majority are **optimistic** and **motivated** about achieving their goals.

They are **primarily motivated by extrinsic factors**: earning a promotion and advancing into influential leadership roles.

Their development is focused on deeper domain mastery and internal leadership opportunities (e.g., team lead, mentor), and are pursuing this through hands on experience. We can help them by **deepening their knowledge, helping them navigate internally, identifying skill gaps, and offering networking to stay ahead of their peers.**

Hear from: Lou

What they are up against

A sense of limited opportunities for promotion, feeling like their managers or employer do not recognize their value, and a fear of organizational restructuring makes it difficult for Mid-Level Loyalists to reach their advancement goals

They are aiming for **promotion** by performing their current role to the best of their ability.

[Barriers: limited opportunities for promotion (28%), managers / employers not recognizing their value (19%), facing competition (17%), organizational restructuring (15%).

Goals

1. Increase earning potential (41%)
2. Earn a promotion (39%)
3. Advance into an executive or sr. leadership role (30%)
4. Develop my leadership or management skills (29%)
5. Make a meaningful impact (22%)

Dev Triggers

1. Desire to advance (50%)
2. Personally motivated to learn and grow (43%)
3. Needing to learn new skills to stay competitive (34%)
4. Feeling stuck in my current role (26%)
5. Influenced by professional network (24%)

Key Demos & Stats

- **Size:** 17%
- **Mean Age:** 43 | **Gender**: 54% M
- **Titles**: 55% Manager / 13% Senior Manager / 22% Director / 10% Sr. Director
- **Management**: 54% have been managing people for 5+ years with 70% managing teams of 5+
- **Learning Orientation:** 62% Achievers
- **Industries**: healthcare, public sector, tech, logistics / manufacturing
- **Functions**: Sales, Biz Dev, HR, Finance, Product Management

Certificate Subjects

Types: General professional development / MBA (50%), Personal Development (42%), Skill-based professional development (4250, emerging tech (40%)

Top Tier 1 Subjects:

- Project Mgmt (53%)
- Strategic Leadership (42%)
- AI (43%)
- Team Leadership (41%)
- Emerging Technologies (38%)
- Growth Strategy (34%)
- Strategic Planning (31%)
- Data Analysis and Decision Making (29%)

How we win

Benefits:

- Real world hands on experience
- More structured learning paths and clear progression steps
- Affordable or accessible options
- Higher quality content
- Value interactivity (On Call)
- Relationship resources rank high for them

Resources

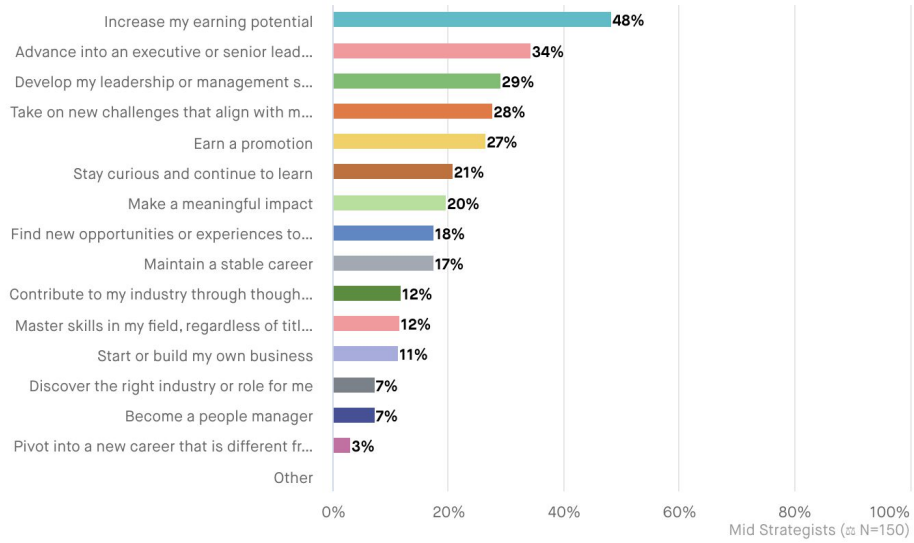
Certificates / Education: Hands-on experience through job, conferences / workshops / seminars, LinkedIn Learning, Coursera
Podcasts: How to be Awesome at Your Job
AI: ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini
Relationships: Networking with colleagues / industry, professional communities, mentorship

	Mid Strategist	Early Strategist	Status
Certificate Program	38	51	**Crawl**
Human Career Coach	33	-2	No Coach **Walk:** Scope / Align: AI Coach that addresses AI hesitations
Professional Networking:	32	19	No Networking at launch **Walk:** Research: What is our role in this space?
Expert-led Classes	28	35	The cert content itself **Walk:** Ideas: Core Content v. Individual At Work
Personalized Learning Paths	23	14	User can select projects most relevant to their role / industry. Personalized feedback on projects. **Walk:** Research: What are the other personalized learning experiences we'd want to deliver?
Goal Setting & Learning Dashboard	8	15	User articulates goal at beginning of course. **Walk:** Research: How might we help users work towards longer term career goals, with certificates as key moments along that journey?
Personalized Career Mapping	3	4	**Walk:** Research: What industries + roles would be most important to serve? How do we do this credibly in a way that is feasible and scalable?
Skill Assessment & Benchmarking	3	22	
Industry Insights & Trends	2	-15	
Micro-Courses	1	10	Module 0 for AI certificates **Run/Not Now:** To consider as our content ages.
Personal Brand Toolkit	-22	-17	LinkedIn Posting Integration **Run/Not Now:**
AI Career Coach	-24	-22	**Walk:** See [Human Career Coach] Line
AI Mentors	-28	-34	
Interactive Role Play	-32	-20	**Run/Not Now:**
Gamified Learning Paths	-64	-43	Progress Bar

Goals

Mid Strategists

Q16 - Goals Aided



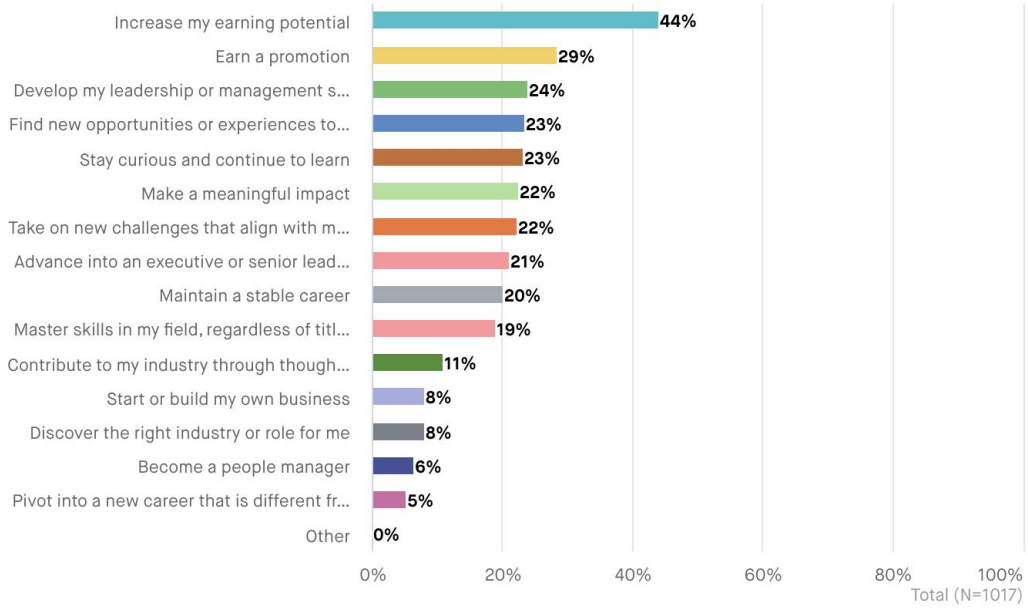
Q16 - Goals Aided: From the list below, which three best align with your current professional goals?

Goals

Total Pop

Q16 - Goals Aided

PowerPoint Export



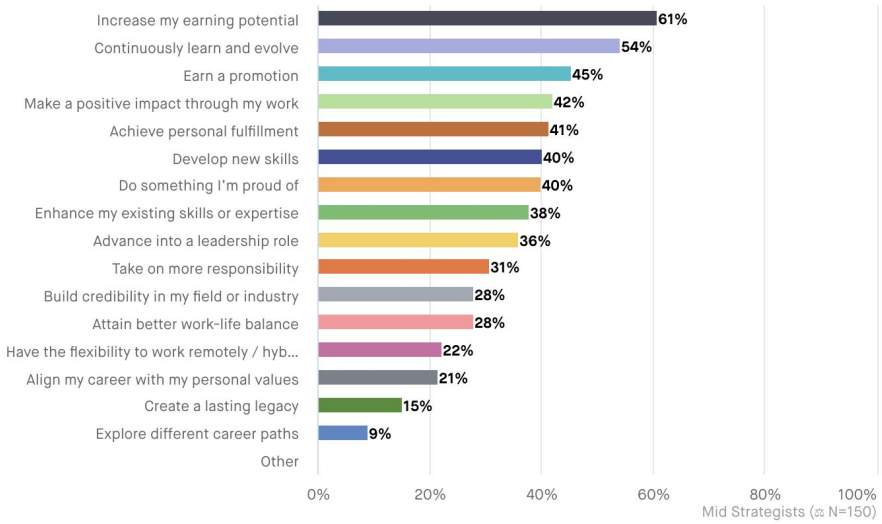
Q16 - Goals Aided: From the list below, which three best align with your current professional goals?

Motivators

Mid Strategists

Select all

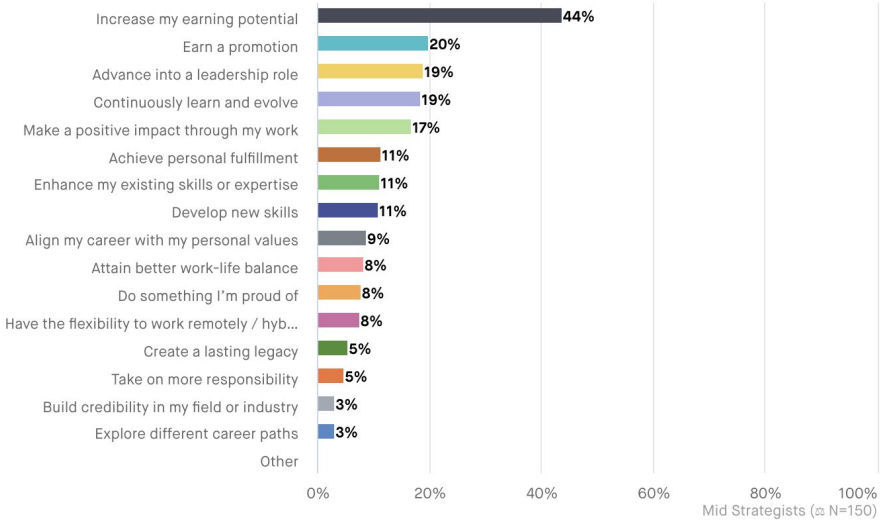
Q20 - Motivators - Aided



Q20 - Motivators - Aided: What motivates you to advance in your career?

Select one

Q21 - Motivators - Forced



Q21 - Motivators - Forced: What most motivates you to advance your career?

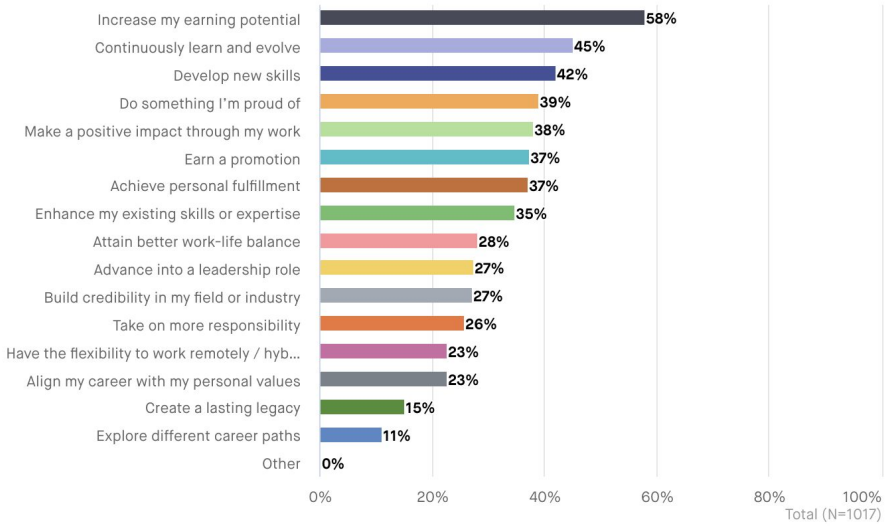
Motivators

Total Pop

Select all

Q20 - Motivators - Aided

PowerPoint Export

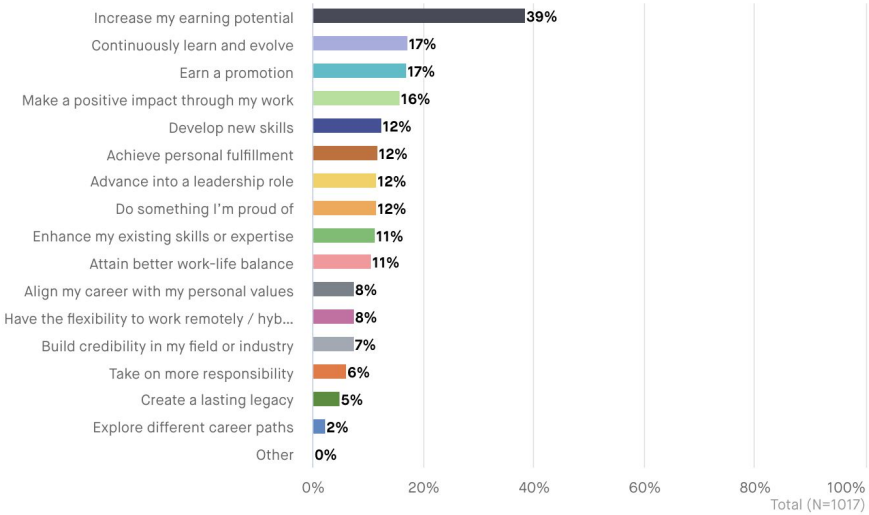


Q20 - Motivators - Aided: What motivates you to advance in your career?

Select one

Q21 - Motivators - Forced

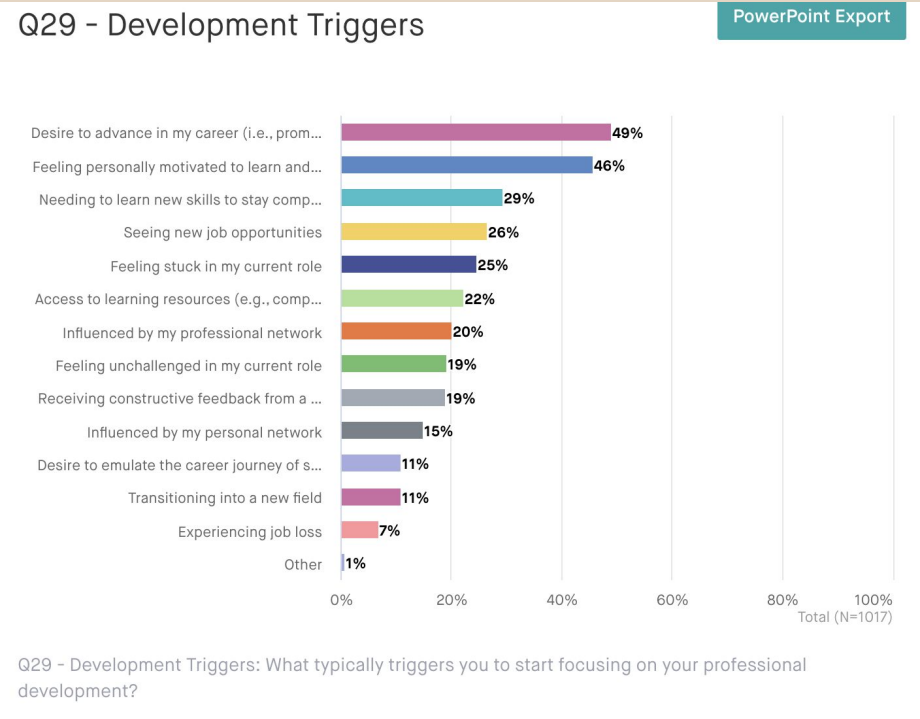
PowerPoint Export



Q21 - Motivators - Forced: What most motivates you to advance your career?

Development Triggers

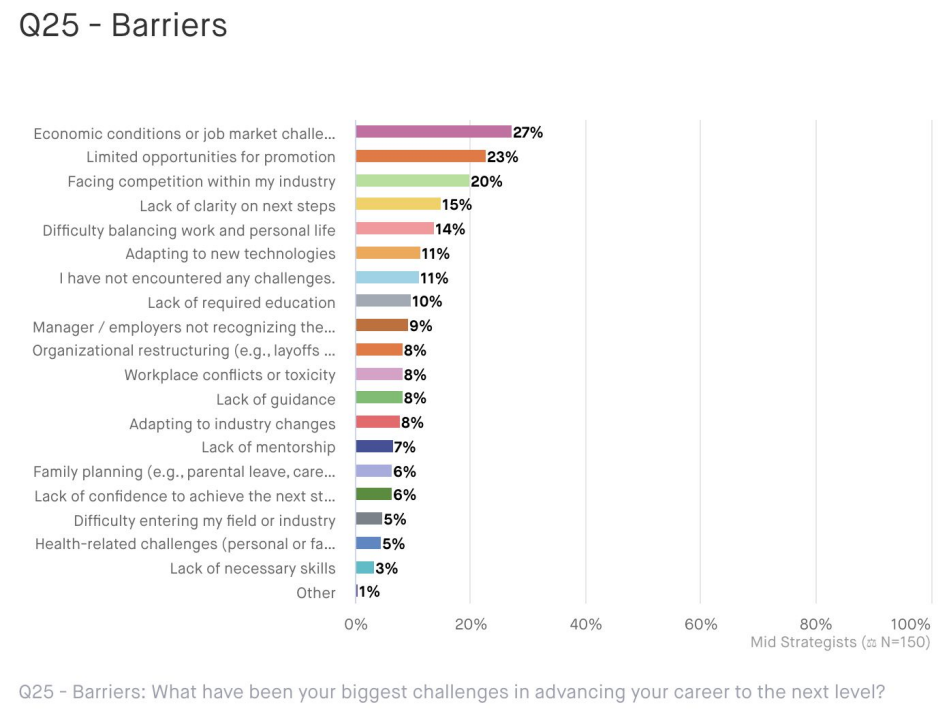
Total Pop



Barriers

Mid Strategists

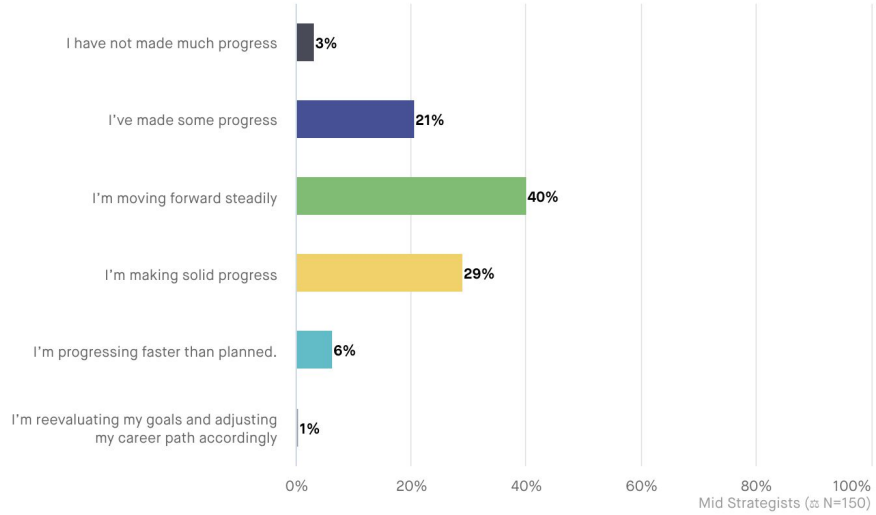
Select up to 3.



Feelings

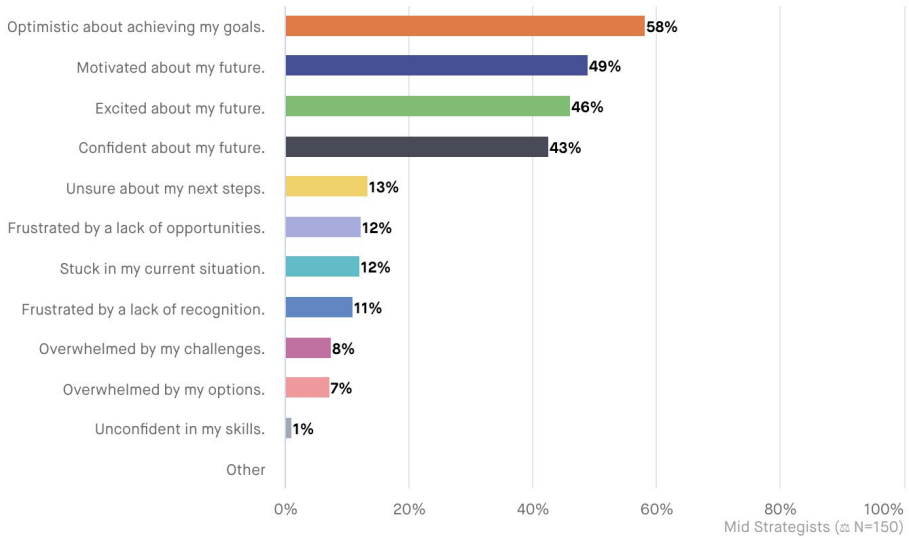
Mid Strategists

Q17 - Progression Single Select



Q17 - Progression Single Select: How would you describe your progress toward achieving your professional goals?

Q24 - Career Journey Feeling

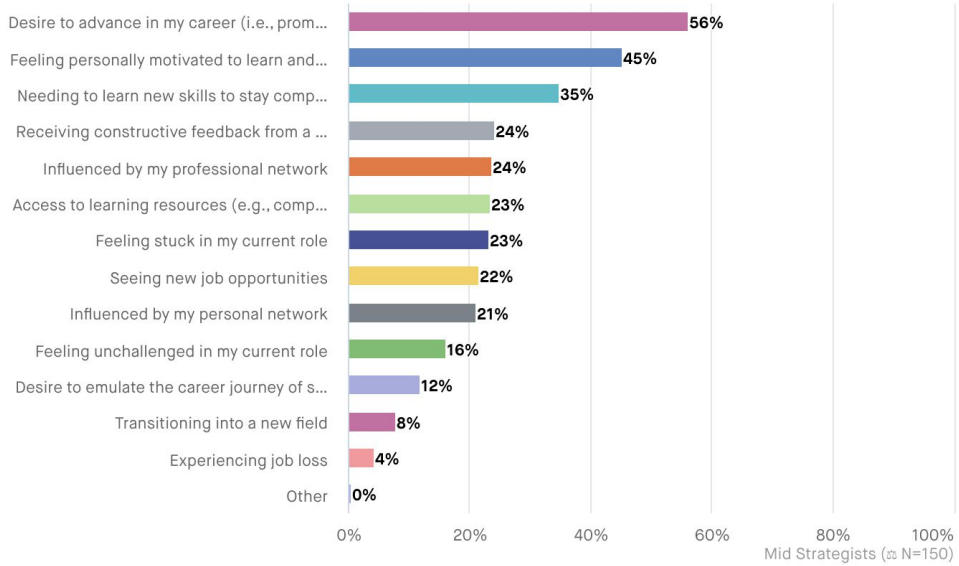


Q24 - Career Journey Feeling: How do you currently feel about your career journey?

Development Triggers

Mid Strategists

Q29 - Development Triggers

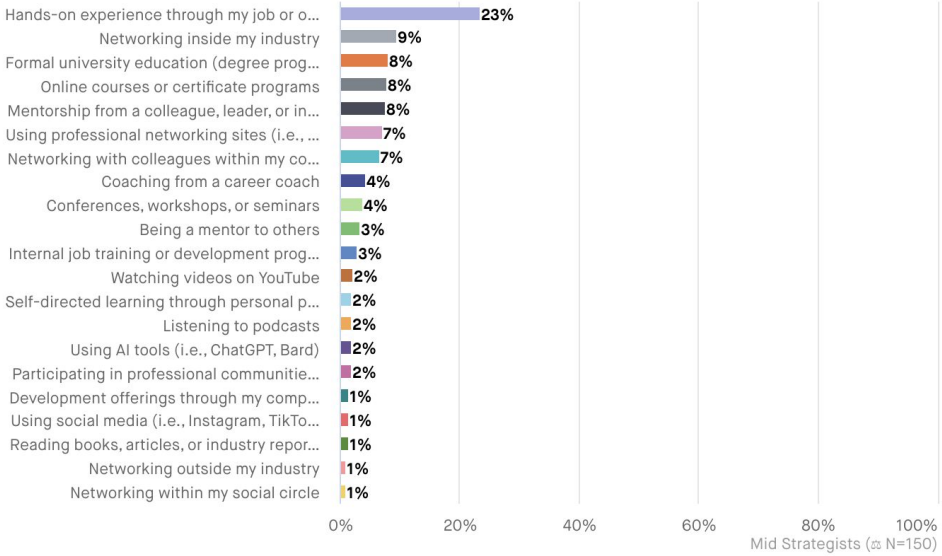


Q29 - Development Triggers: What typically triggers you to start focusing on your professional development?

Resources

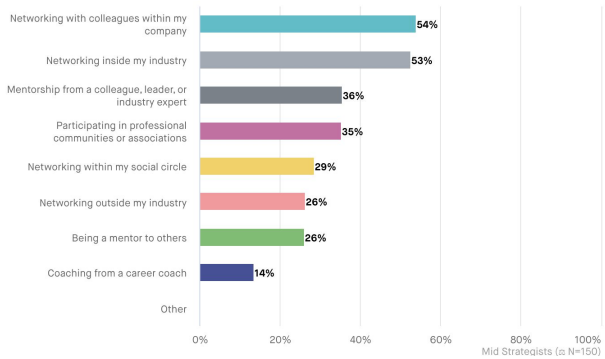
Mid Strategists

Q32 - Most Effective Resource

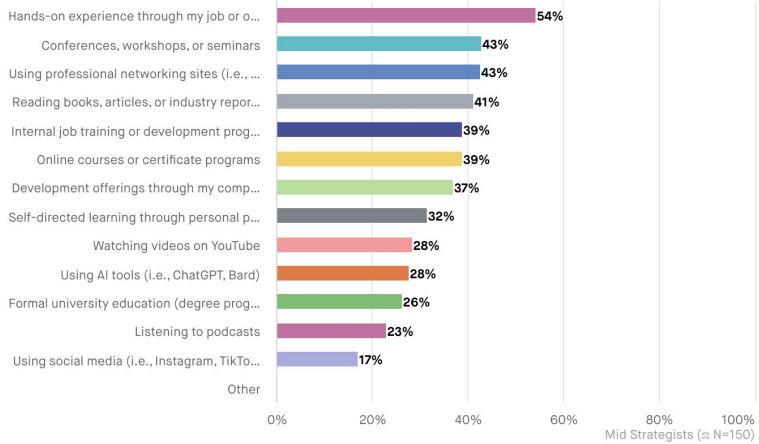


Q32 - Most Effective Resource: If you had to choose just one, which would you say has been the most effective resource in helping you advance your career?

Q30 - Resources Used - Relationship



Q31 - Resources Used - Skills

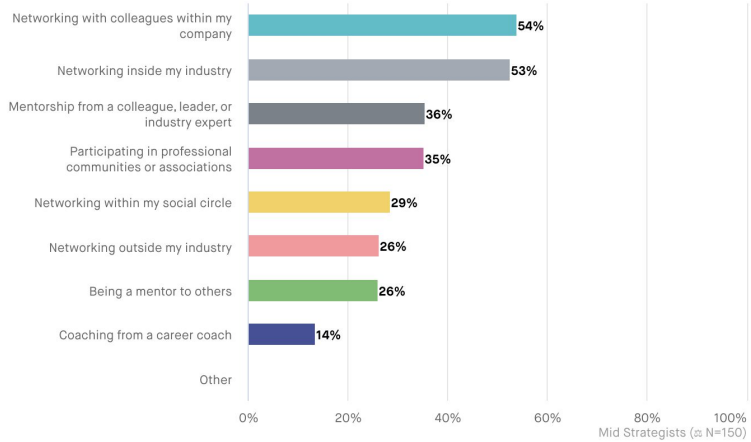


Q31 - Resources Used - Skills: Which skill-building resources do you rely on to advance your career?

Resources (1)

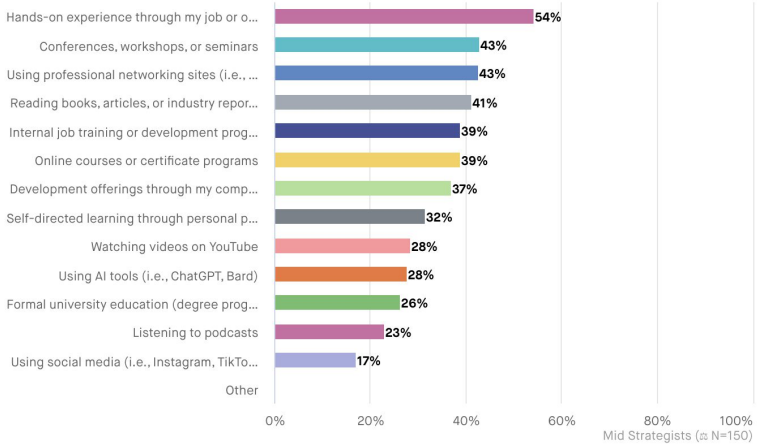
Mid Strategists

Q30 - Resources Used - Relationship



Q30 - Resources Used - Relationship: Which relationship-building resources do you rely on to advance your career?

Q31 - Resources Used - Skills

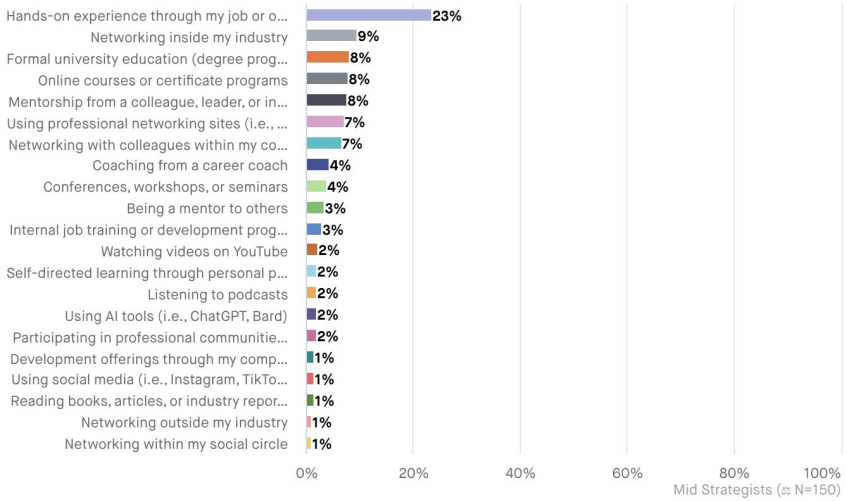


Q31 - Resources Used - Skills: Which skill-building resources do you rely on to advance your career?

Resources (2)

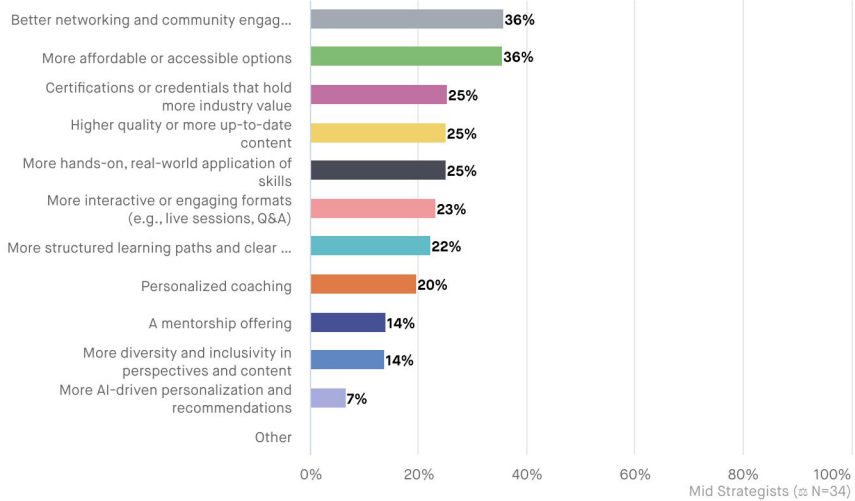
Mid Strategists

Q32 - Most Effective Resource



Q32 - Most Effective Resource: If you had to choose just one, which would you say has been the most effective resource in helping you advance your career?

Q34 - Missing from Resources Today



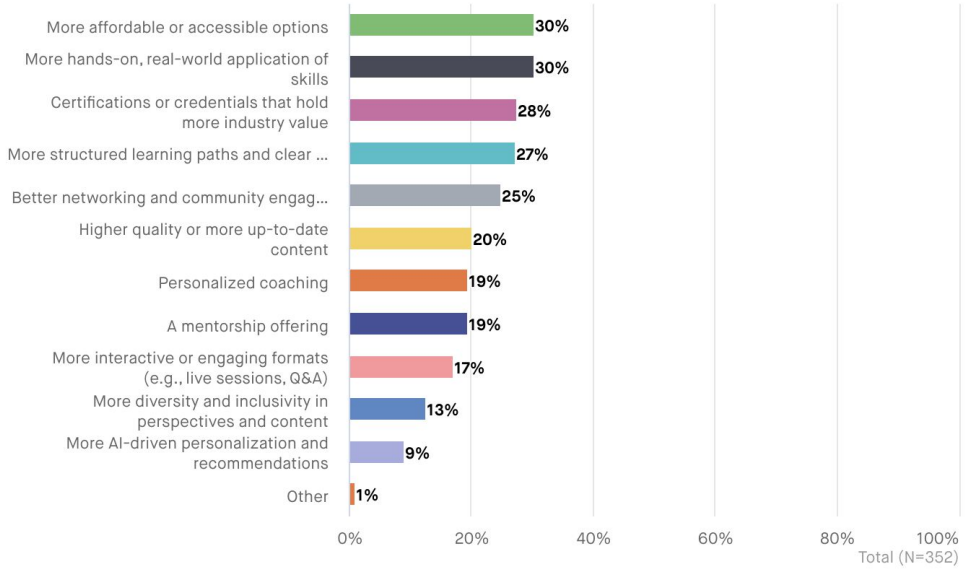
Q34 - Missing from Resources Today: What do you think is missing from resources you use today that would improve your satisfaction with them?

Resources

Total Pop

Q34 - Missing from Resources Today

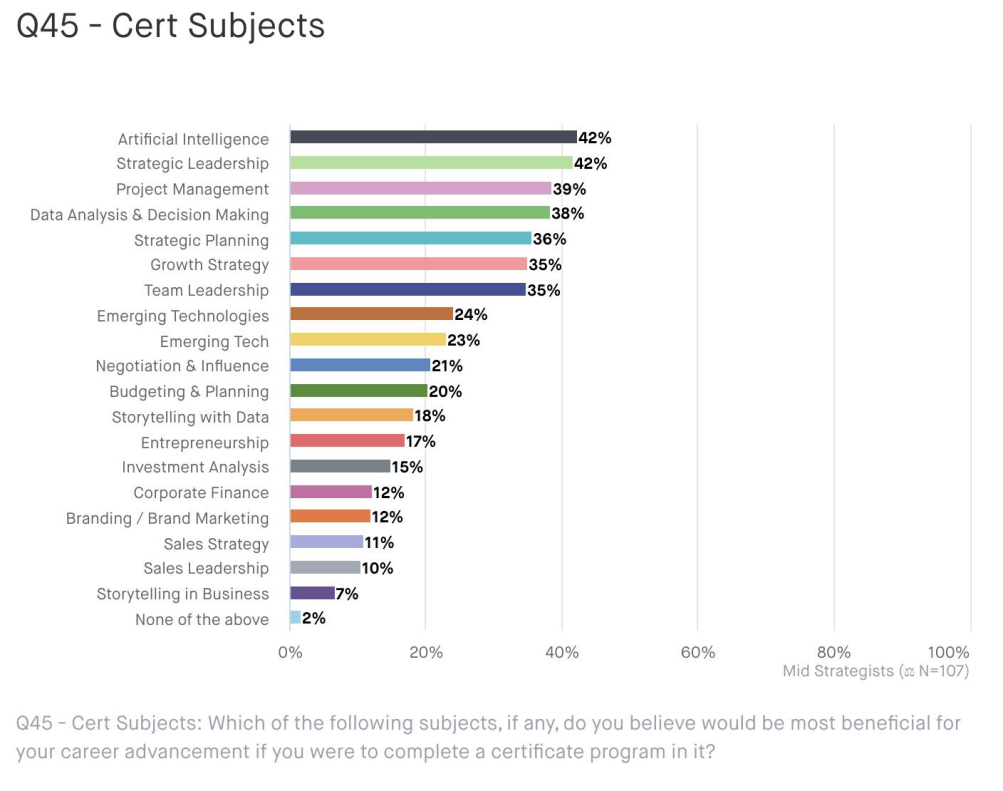
PowerPoint Export



Q34 - Missing from Resources Today: What do you think is missing from resources you use today that would improve your satisfaction with them?

Certificate Subjects

Mid Strategists

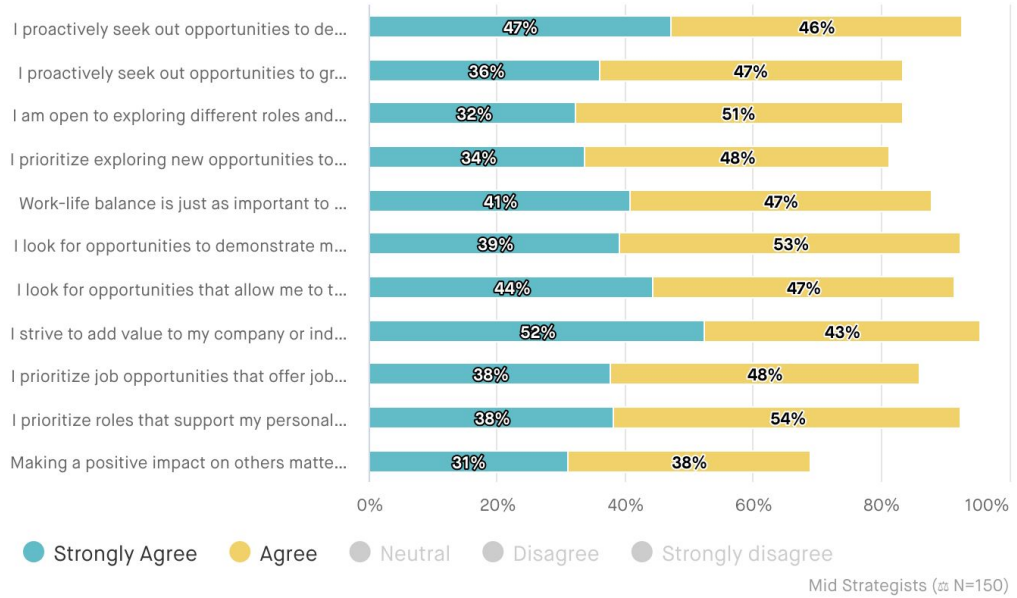


Strategic Leadership	43%
Project Management	41%
Artificial Intelligence	40%
Data Analysis & Decision Making	38%
Team Leadership	37%
Strategic Planning	36%
Growth Strategy	33%
Emerging Technologies	27%
Emerging Tech	21%
Negotiation & Influence	21%
Budgeting & Planning	19%
Storytelling with Data	18%
Entrepreneurship	17%
Investment Analysis	14%
Corporate Finance	13%
Branding / Brand Marketing	13%
Sales Strategy	11%
Sales Leadership	10%
Storytelling in Business	9%
None of the above	1%

Psychographics

Mid Strategists

Q51 - Psychographics



Q51 - Psychographics: Do you agree or disagree that these statements describe you? | 1: “Strongly disagree” - 5: “Strongly Agree”